

What works on YouTube, for many.

You list the channels in your niche. Five small steps later you know which of their breakout topics have worked for many different channels, not just one. This guide walks through every step with a real example. It needs no Google Ads access.

THE IDEA

One hit is a story. Twelve hits are a pattern.

Every niche has videos that blew up. Copying one rarely works, because a video's views have four causes and only one of them is the topic.

$$\text{views} \approx \text{channel} \times \text{topic} \times \text{packaging} \times \text{luck}$$

This pipeline starts from the breakout videos of the channels you list, works out the topic under each one, and then asks YouTube whether that topic has worked for many other channels too. A real result, from 24 AI and tech channels:

TOPIC	BEST PHRASING	REPEATABILITY	CHANNELS	VERDICT
GPT-6 Astra	gpt 6 astra free	4.57	13	repeatable
Claude Code	claude code tutorial for beginners	4.52	18	repeatable
AI agents	ai agents tutorial	3.54	16	repeatable
PDF compression	compress pdf without losing quality	2.61	12	repeatable
Gemma 4	gemma 4b	2.33	8	repeatable
AI login automation	ai login automation	1.40	10	not repeatable

Six of the eight topics of the run. A topic is judged by its best phrasing.

THE PRINCIPLE BEHIND IT

One viral video proves little. The same topic working for 18 channels proves a lot.

Packaging and luck differ from channel to channel. When many unrelated channels all beat their own normal with the same topic, the thing they share is the topic.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Packaging Title, thumbnail and hook: how a video is sold, as opposed to what it is about.

Channels How many different channels had a hit with the topic.

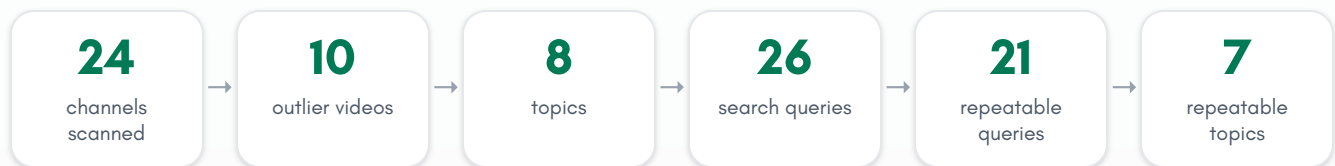
Score THE REPEATABILITY COLUMN Each hit adds between 0 and 1: more when recent and from a channel your size. The score is the total.

Five steps. Each one asks one question.

Every step takes the previous step's answer, does one small thing, and saves what went in and what came out. The colour tells you where the answer comes from.

1	YouTube	Find outliers	Which videos far outperformed their own channel?
2	LLM	Outliers to topics	Which topics are those videos about?
3	YouTube	Search queries	What do viewers really type to find them? (a: YouTube, b: LLM)
4	YouTube	Repeatability	Has each search query worked for many channels?
5	Rule	Scoreboard	Which topics are repeatable?

The same run, as a funnel



Real numbers from the run on the previous page.

WHERE PIPELINE 3 GOES FROM HERE

These five steps answer "is it repeatable?". Pipeline 3 runs the same steps and then asks Google whether each repeatable topic is also **rising** in search. If you have Google Ads access, use pipeline 3. If not, this pipeline is the whole YouTube half, and it costs nothing but YouTube quota.

THREE KINDS OF STEP

YouTube steps fetch facts. **Rule** steps are plain arithmetic. **LLM** steps use an AI model only to translate between how people talk: a video title, a YouTube search. The numbers never come from the model.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Outlier A video from one of your listed channels with at least 5 times that channel's normal views.

Search query The words a viewer types into YouTube's search box.

LLM A large language model: an AI that reads and writes text, like ChatGPT or Claude.

Quota YouTube's daily allowance: 10,000 units. One search costs 100.

Which videos far outperformed their own channel?

For each channel on your list, the pipeline finds the channel's normal: the median views of its last 50 uploads. A video at 5 times that normal is an outlier. The 10 biggest go on.

GOES IN

@nicksaraev

@mreflow

@howiaipodcast

@PavanLalwani

and **20** more channels from config.py.

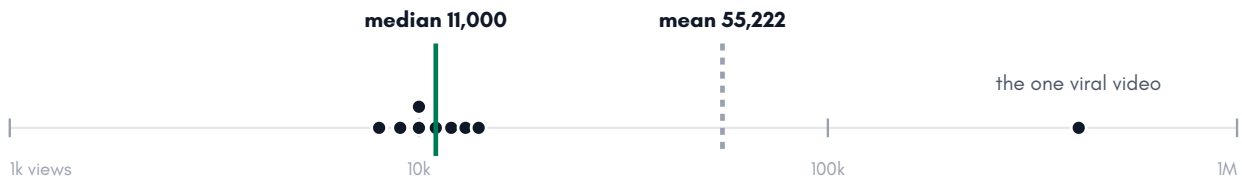
COMES OUT

"Convert Image PDF to Editable Text" **6.1M** vs **28,012** normal = **217x**

"CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS" **2.5M** vs **79,758** = **31.5x**

"Build Your First AI Agent in 10 Minutes" **315,881** vs **14,753** = **21.4x**

10 outlier videos.



Nine uploads of an imaginary channel. The average says a normal video gets 54,000 views. The median says 11,000, the truth.

WHY IT WORKS

Compare a channel with itself.

Raw views mostly measure how big the channel is. A channel's own normal cancels that out. The normal is the median, not the average, because one viral video drags an average far too high.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- It can only find topics the channels on your list have made. The list is the most important setting.
- One outlier is one data point. It may be luck or a great thumbnail. That is why steps 3 and 4 exist.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Channel's normal The median views of its last 50 uploads: half got more, half got less.

Outlier A video from one of your listed channels with at least 5 times that channel's normal views.

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.find_outliers @Fireship`

SAVED AS `01_find_outliers.json`

Which topics are those videos about?

An AI model reads each outlier's title and the first lines of its description, and names the topic underneath, with the plain search query a viewer would type. Videos about the same thing become one topic.

GOES IN

"GPT-6 Astra Is Finally Here (And It's REALLY Good)"

description: Here's my first look at GPT-6-Astra after spending some time using it myself ...

"I Tested GPT 6 Astra vs Fable 5.1 (No Hype ...)"

"CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS: Build & Sell"

and 7 more outlier videos, each with its description.

COMES OUT

GPT-6 Astra · 2 videos "gpt 6 astra"

Claude Code · 1 "claude code
video tutorial"

PDF compression "compress pdf without
· 1 video losing quality"

8 topics, each with a search query.

WHY IT WORKS

A title is packaging. The topic is what is underneath.

"Is Finally Here (And It's REALLY Good)" is how one creator sold the video. The description is where creators usually say plainly what a video covers. Reading through the packaging is a language task, so it goes to a language model.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- Many descriptions open with sponsor links and say nothing about the video. Then the title is all the model has.
- The search query is the model's guess. It can be too specific for what people really type. Step 3 corrects for that.
- A different model may split or merge topics differently.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Topic What a video is about. One topic covers many keywords and wordings.

Search query The words a viewer types into YouTube's search box.

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.outliers_to_topics` (one small LLM call)

SAVED AS 02_outliers_to_topics.json

What does YouTube's search box suggest?

Type something into YouTube and it finishes your sentence. Those suggestions are what viewers really type, most popular first. The pipeline asks for them, for every topic's query. It is free and needs no key.

GOES IN

claude code tutorial

One topic's search query.



COMES OUT

claude code tutorial for beginners

claude code tutorial mac

claude code tutorial vscode

claude code tutorial for developers

claude code tutorial for non coders

and 4 more suggestions.

WHY IT WORKS

Ask the crowd how they phrase it.

A model guessed the query in step 2. YouTube's search box knows what millions of viewers actually typed. Real phrasings beat guessed ones, because the search results, and so the evidence, depend on the exact words.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- It gives an order, not numbers. You learn what is popular, not how popular.
- Long, specific queries get few suggestions or none. Short queries work best.
- It is an unofficial address that YouTube could change without notice. If it fails, the pipeline goes on with the topic's own query.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Suggestions What YouTube's search box offers while you type (autocomplete).

Search query FROM STEP 2 The words a viewer types into YouTube's search box.

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.youtube_suggestions "claude code"`

SAVED AS `03_a_youtube_suggestions.json`

Which phrasings are worth a search of their own?

An AI model says keep or drop for each suggestion: same language, still on topic, a different angle or audience. Then YouTube's own order decides: the 3 most popular of the kept ones go on. Each is scored in the next step as an idea of its own.

GOES IN

claude code	+ 9
tutorial	suggestions
gpt 6 astra	+ 9 suggestions
ai agents	+ 9 suggestions

8 topics with their suggestions.



COMES OUT

claude code tutorial	the topic's own query
claude code tutorial for beginners	kept · YouTube's #1
claude code tutorial vscode	kept · #3
claude code tutorial for non coders	kept · #7

26 search queries for the 8 topics.

WHY IT WORKS

The same topic can win under one phrasing and lose under another.

"For beginners" and "for non coders" are different audiences, with different videos competing. In this run the first scored 4.52 and the second 2.56. The guardrail: a pick that is not in YouTube's list is thrown away, so the model cannot invent a query.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- Every extra query costs a YouTube search: 26 searches are 2,600 of your 10,000 daily units.
- "A different angle" is a judgement. And popularity is YouTube's, so expect an odd one now and then, such as "gpt 6 astra roblox", its #2 suggestion.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Phrasing One way of wording a topic, such as "claude code for beginners".

Quota YouTube's daily allowance: 10,000 units. One search costs 100.

Guardrail A check on the AI model: it may only pick from the real list it was given.

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.query_variants "claude code"`

SAVED AS `03_b_query_variants.json`

Has each search query worked for many channels?

One YouTube search per query. Every result is compared with what **its own channel** normally gets. A video at 4 times its channel's normal is a hit. Every hit adds to the query's score, and newer hits, and hits from channels near your size, add more.

GOES IN

claude code tutorial for beginners

gpt 6 astra free

ai agents tutorial

python ocr pdf to text

and **22** more search queries. One YouTube search each.



COMES OUT

gpt 6 astra free 15 hits · 13 channels · **4.57**

claude code tutorial for beginners 25 hits · 18 channels · **4.52**

ai agents tutorial 25 hits · 16 channels · **3.54**

python ocr pdf to text 8 hits · 6 channels · **0.66**

The last number on each line is the query's score.

The next page works through one of these scores by hand.

WHY IT WORKS

Divide by the channel, then demand many channels.

A video's views come from the channel, the topic, the packaging and luck. Dividing by what the channel normally gets cancels the channel. Asking for hits on many unrelated channels cancels packaging and luck, because those differ from channel to channel. What is left is the topic.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- It only sees the videos YouTube's search returns. Most flops on the topic stay invisible.
- The bars (4 times normal, 6 channels, the score) are judgement calls. You can change them.
- It measures the topic, not you. A repeatable topic still needs a good title, thumbnail and video.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Channel's normal The median views of its last 50 uploads: half got more, half got less.

Hit A search result with at least 4 times its channel's normal views.

Score Each hit adds between 0 and 1: more when recent and from a channel your size. The score is the total.

Repeatable Hits on 6 or more different channels, and a score of 2.0 or more.

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.score_repeatability "claude code"`

SAVED AS 04_score_repeatability.json

How "claude code tutorial for beginners" got its score of 4.52.

1 Search, and set aside what can't be compared

YouTube returns up to 50 videos for the query. Videos older than 2 years, or with under 1,000 views, are set aside.

2 Is each video a hit? $\text{views} \div \text{its channel's normal} \geq 4$

VIDEO	VIEWS	CHANNEL'S NORMAL	RESULT
"FULL Claude Code Tutorial ..." · Productive Dude	14,139	799	17.7x hit
"The Ultimate Beginner's Guide ..." · Metics Media	925,616	14,761	62.7x hit
"I Have Spent 1000+ Hours ..." · The Coding Sloth	640,550	147,815	4.3x hit

This search found 25 hits, on 18 different channels. A video at 2 times normal adds nothing.

3 How much does each hit count? $\text{freshness} \times \text{closeness}$

Freshness halves every 180 days: today 1.0, six months 0.5, a year 0.25. **Closeness** is 1.0 for a channel your size, 0.5 for one 10 times bigger or smaller, 0.33 for 100 times, 0.25 for 1,000 times. In this run your channel's normal is about 140 views.

HIT	AGE → FRESHNESS	CHANNEL SIZE → CLOSNESS	COUNTS FOR
Productive Dude	157 days → 0.55	5.6 times yours → 0.57	$0.55 \times 0.57 = 0.31$
Metics Media	42 days → 0.85	104 times yours → 0.33	$0.85 \times 0.33 = 0.28$
The Coding Sloth	34 days → 0.88	1,037 times yours → 0.25	$0.88 \times 0.25 = 0.22$

The 62.7x hit counts for less than the 17.7x hit. How big a hit was does not matter. How recent it is, and how much the channel is like yours, does.

4 Add up all 25 hits

$$0.31 + 0.31 + 0.28 + 0.26 + 21 \text{ smaller ones} = 4.52$$

5 The verdict: two tests, both must pass

SEARCH QUERY	CHANNELS WITH A HIT (6 OR MORE)	SCORE (2.0 OR MORE)	VERDICT
claude code tutorial for beginners	18 pass	4.52 pass	repeatable
python ocr pdf to text	6 pass	0.66 fail	not repeatable

6 A topic is judged by its best phrasing

The topic Claude Code was searched four ways: "for beginners" 4.52, "claude code tutorial" 3.37, "vscode" 3.12, "for non coders" 2.56. The topic takes the best one, 4.52, and that phrasing is the one to build your title around.

Which topics are repeatable?

The last step puts one row per topic on a scoreboard: the best phrasing, its score and its channels, and the verdict.

GOES IN

The topics and their YouTube scores.



COMES OUT

GPT-6 Astra

repeatable

Claude Code

repeatable

Gemma 4

repeatable

AI login automation

not repeatable

7 of 8 topics are repeatable.

WHY IT WORKS

A topic is judged by its best phrasing.

Claude Code was searched four ways. "For beginners" scored 4.52 and "for non coders" 2.56. The topic takes the best, and that phrasing is the one to build your title around. Every step saved its work, so you can walk back to the hits behind any score.

WHERE IT FALLS SHORT

- "Repeatable" means the topic has worked for many channels. It does not say whether the audience is growing. That is the Google test, in pipeline 3.
- The data moves. Run it again before you commit weeks to a topic.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Verdict The pipeline's conclusion for a topic. It always comes with its reason.

Repeatable FROM STEP 4 Hits on 6 or more different channels, and a score of 2.0 or more.

Phrasing FROM STEP 3B One way of wording a topic, such as "claude code for beginners".

TRY IT `uv run python -m steps.scoreboard` (needs no keys)

SAVED AS 05_scoreboard.json and scoreboard.csv

What this pipeline can't tell you.

It turns other channels' results into evidence about topics. It is not an oracle. Knowing where it is weak is what lets you trust it where it is strong.

LIMIT	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
It only sees the channels you list	A topic none of them has made stays invisible. List the channels of your niche, including small ones, and refresh the list now and then.
You only see the winners	YouTube shows the videos that did well. The many that flopped on the same topic are mostly hidden. Asking for hits on 6 or more channels reduces this. It does not remove it.
It says nothing about demand	Repeatable means it worked for others. Whether more people want it than last year is a Google question: pipeline 3 asks it.
It costs quota	Every search query costs 100 of your 10,000 daily YouTube units. This run's 26 searches cost 2,600. Answers are kept for 24 hours, so running again the same day is free.
The thresholds are opinions	5 times normal, 4 times normal, 6 channels, 180 days. They are all named settings in config.py. Change one, run again, and see which verdicts move.

FIRST PRINCIPLE

A model you can't inspect, you can't improve.

Every step saves a file with a summary, what went in and what came out. When a verdict surprises you, open the run folder and walk back, file by file, to the step that caused it.

WORDS ON THIS PAGE

Quota YouTube's daily allowance: 10,000 units. One search costs 100.

Cache Answers from YouTube and the AI model are stored for 24 hours, so running again the same day is free.

config.py The settings file. Every number in this guide is a named setting in it.

RUN IT YOURSELF

One command.

Set it up once and list the channels of your niche. A page opens in your browser that shows every step of the run.

<code>cp .env.example .env</code>	your YouTube and LLM keys
<code>cp config.py.example config.py</code>	your channel, and the channels to scan
<code>uv run pipeline_1_youtube_repeatable_outliers.py</code>	run it

No Google Ads access needed. When you have it, pipeline 3 adds the Google side.